

LAND OF TEMPLES AND CITIES

Central and South America

Negotiating the challenging terrain of Mesoamerica and the Andean region without wheeled transportation, early civilizations of South and Central America produced an extraordinary number of impressive structural feats. Their engineering innovations included precision-cut, mortar-free masonry that was earthquake-proof, agricultural terracing that channeled water through every step, and pressurized water systems. Recurring themes were mastery of geometrical forms and extravagant decoration, such as the gold sheeting employed by the Incas. Colonization in the 16th century devastated the indigenous culture while transforming the built environment with elaborate edifices and ambitious schemes that in scale and grandeur were reminiscent of the Incan and Pre-Columbian civilizations. During the 20th century and beyond, the blending of indigenous and European elements evolved into novel modern architectural styles adapted to the local climate and materials.

rising to prominence from c.600–1200 CE, Chichén Itzá was one of the largest cities built by the Maya civilization

MOUNTAIN AND FOREST PIONEERS

Pre-Columbian cultures populated the rainforests and mountaintops of Central and South America with stone cities and temple complexes in astronomically significant locations. Colonization introduced new European styles, and the ensuing deforestation paved the way for the Industrial Age and modern architecture.

KEY SITES

- | | |
|------------------------------|---|
| 1 Calakmul | 13 Machu Picchu |
| 2 Tikal | 14 Church of Santa Prisca |
| 3 Nazca Lines | 15 San Ignacio Mini |
| 4 Monte Albán | 16 Citadelle Laferrière |
| 5 Teotihuacán | 17 Panama Canal |
| 6 Chichén Itzá | 18 Christ the Redeemer |
| 7 Copán | 19 Cathedral of Brasília |
| 8 Yaxchilán | 20 Central University City Campus of UNAM |
| 9 Temple of the Inscriptions | 21 Salt Cathedral of Zipaquirá |
| 10 Sacsayhuamán | 22 Niterói Contemporary Art Museum |
| 11 Chan Chan | 23 Itaipu Dam |
| 12 Easter Island Moai | |

a mountaintop fortress, Citadelle Laferrière was built in 1805–1820 by Henri Christophe, a leading figure in the Haitian Revolution

West Indies

Greater Antilles

Lesser Antilles

Windward Islands

Puerto Rico

Hispaniola

Cuba

Jamaica

Caribbean Sea

Gulf of Mexico

Bahamas

Lake Maracaibo

Apure

Orinoco

Guiana Highlands

Amazon

Serra dos Carajás

Amazon Basin

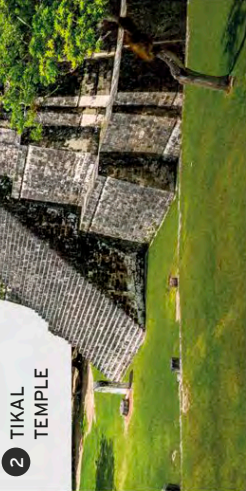
ATLANTIC OCEAN

PRE-COLUMBIAN KINGDOMS

c.1200 BCE–1550 CE

Rising from the Central American jungle, the step pyramids of ancient Olmec culture gave way to the elaborate designs of the Maya, who masterminded the biggest cities in the world. Mesoamerican architects became renowned for their knowledge of astronomy, their engineering prowess, and their skillful incorporation of symbolic references.

2 TIKAL TEMPLE



MONOLITH BUILDERS

900–1600

From the highland plateaus of southern Colombia to the far-flung reaches of the southeastern Pacific, distinct indigenous cultures executed similar feats of stone construction and carving in the form of giant monoliths. Most notable are more than 800 moai erected by the Rapa Nui people of Easter Island.

12 EASTER ISLAND MOAI

